

The background features a series of concentric circles in light gray, some solid and some dashed, creating a ripple effect. A large green speech bubble is centered on the page, containing the title text in white.

THE ELEMENTS OF STORYTELLING

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Outcomes

- Discover the principles of storytelling
- Learn about the traditional three-act structure
- Learn how to apply storytelling and the three-act structure

The six elements of storytelling

- That pattern begins with the six elements of storytelling.
- The ingredients to just about any story are as follows: ***characters, plot, conflict, resolution, setting, and theme.***
- Understanding what makes a good story will help you organize stories around what viewers want to see.
- There's much that you can do with multimedia to improve the user experience by using the principles of storytelling.

Character

- The story is about characters. You can't tell a story without characters.
- Some of the best shows on TV are character driven. They introduce characters and each week reveal more and more about what makes each of them tick.

Character: Background

- Background tells the past of your characters—where they came from, what events in their past are influencing their present actions.
- People will seldom act without a good cause. It's what police officers call the motive. Often, you'll need to look further than the events at hand.
- If you plan to tell an original story, this means thinking about who the characters are, in what country they were born, how old they are, gender, ethnicity, political views, physical attributes, hobbies...anything relevant to the project.

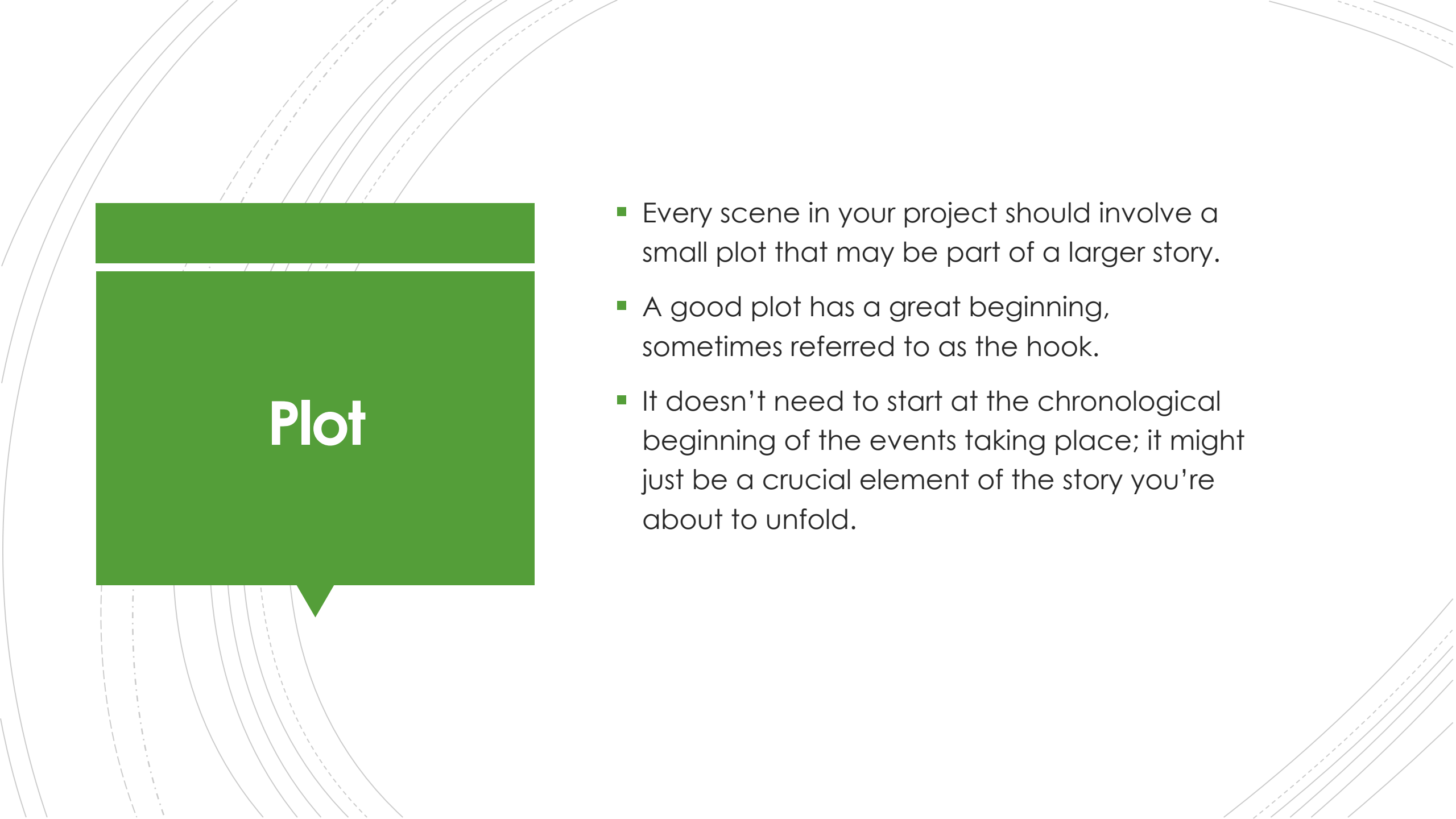
Character:

- **Emotional Involvement:** Give your viewers enough information about your characters so they can relate to them and become emotionally involved. Viewers should care about the characters and want to find out what happens to them as your story is told.
- **Character Arcs:** In traditional storytelling a great deal is made about character arcs. As you begin to tell your story, make sure you have a map of how your character changes through the story. Good stories will show how a character evolves throughout the presentation. You can also choose to reveal things about your character slowly so that the perception about the character changes as you expand your narrative.

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Plot

- The plot is how you tell what happens (or what happened) in a story. Handle plot carefully... it's not simply what happened in a story, but the arrangement of how the story is presented.
- It's the reason people will stay tuned to your projects.
- It's why you just can't put a good book down. You have to read it all the way to the end to find how the events unfold and what happens to the characters you care about.

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Plot

- Every scene in your project should involve a small plot that may be part of a larger story.
- A good plot has a great beginning, sometimes referred to as the hook.
- It doesn't need to start at the chronological beginning of the events taking place; it might just be a crucial element of the story you're about to unfold.

Plot: Point of View

- At the beginning, one of the decisions you have to make about your project is the point of view, the perspective through which the story will be told.
- The typical points of view are: *first person, third person omniscient, and third person limited.*

Plot: Point of View

- **FIRST PERSON:** using a first person point of view, the story is told from the perspective of the person experiencing the plot—their knowledge of events is limited to their own experiences.
- **THIRD PERSON OMNISCIENT:** in third person omniscient, the story is told from the perspective of someone who is aware of everything, even what your characters are thinking.
- **THIRD PERSON LIMITED:** the third person limited perspective is one where an imaginary character follows another character. They may be aware of what is going on, but behave as someone observing a main character.

Plot: Dividing Your Projects

- Plot will help you break your projects down into sections or scenes. Part of organizing a project involves breaking your story into sections.
- **Ask yourself:** *What is this scene about? Make sure that every scene of your project is about something.*
- Create an outline for your project where you consider things such as point of view, plot, characters, and navigation. Once the outline is complete, it will go a long way to assist you in creating storyboards, comps, and navigation.

Conflict

- Most people can put up with a lot of bad movies, but almost no one will put up with a movie without conflict. Conflict is what makes a plot interesting. It drives your characters to action. It's impossible to have a good plot without conflict.
- It's the problem the characters are trying to solve in a story.
- In any multimedia project, conflict can add to the drama and create interest in your presentation. When examining the themes you wish to approach, consider choosing a theme that has a level of conflict.
- It will be easier to hook your readers and keep them interested in your presentation.

Resolution

- The resolution of your story is where you tell how the issues panned out. The resolution is why your viewer sticks around until the end of your presentation.
- The resolution should tie up all the loose ends and bring the conflict to a successful close.
- The resolution of a story provides a payoff to the viewer. If you include a degree of conflict in your projects, make sure you give the user a resolution to that conflict.

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Setting

- Setting is simply where the story is takes place. More than any other element of storytelling, it's where multimedia can have a serious impact.
- You can establish setting through the design of the project, audio, photographs, video, and the words you include in your copy.

Setting: Typography

- Your choice of fonts can have a great impact on setting and readability. For interactive design, you'll need to focus on two types of fonts: your headline fonts and your body fonts.
- Headline fonts are decorative typefaces that are sized bigger than about 18 points throughout your project. You should choose headline fonts that are appropriate to the setting of the project.
- Fonts were carefully crafted to evoke a time period, but it may not be obvious at first, so you should study the history of typefaces.

Setting: Typography

- Body copy should be easy to read; don't make it so small that your viewers have to squint. Also, take into consideration how your project will be viewed.
- If the project is a television commercial, for example, the fonts should be much larger than if it will be viewed on a computer screen.
- Televisions have less resolution than a computer monitor and since the edges of TVs are different sizes and dimensions (normal screens versus flat panels versus wide aspect ratios), you should keep copy away from the edges.

Setting: Design

- The design of your project also helps establish the setting.
- You can use props throughout your design; fonts, colours, and other visual cues will assist you in creating the right environment.
- There are five rules of design you should consider: ***contrast, alignment, proximity, repetition, and subtraction.***

Setting: Design

- Using **contrast** means making things clear. Emphasizing certain elements, making things bigger and smaller is using contrast. Contrast is the most important rule of design; without it, your setting will look bland and uninteresting.
- The rule of **alignment** says that things should align to each other to establish the flow of the viewer's eye movement. Western readers tend to view things from the top left to the bottom right.
- Centring a long paragraph is a good example of bad alignment; when the eyes finish a line of type, it's hard for them to figure out where the next line will be.

Setting: Design

- **Proximity** articulates that things that belong together should be close together. People create associations about objects if they are close together. A headline should be close to its body copy.
- **Repetition** means using the same elements of design throughout your entire project, or series of projects. By using the same fonts, art elements, and alignment, for example, you'll help the viewer become familiar with your project. Repetition yields familiarity.
- **Subtraction** is removing unnecessary parts of your project, those things that do not communicate something to your viewer. Subtraction yields clarity and focus in your projects.

Setting: Audio & Voices

- There are several ways to use audio to establish a setting. Narration, for example, will immediately give cues to the audience as to the tone of the presentation. The tone of the voice and the accent of the speaker speak volumes.
- A narration is also an effective way to make the viewer feel at home.
- When recording for performances (when the audio is to be used with motion graphics or animation), you should ask people to record things more than once.

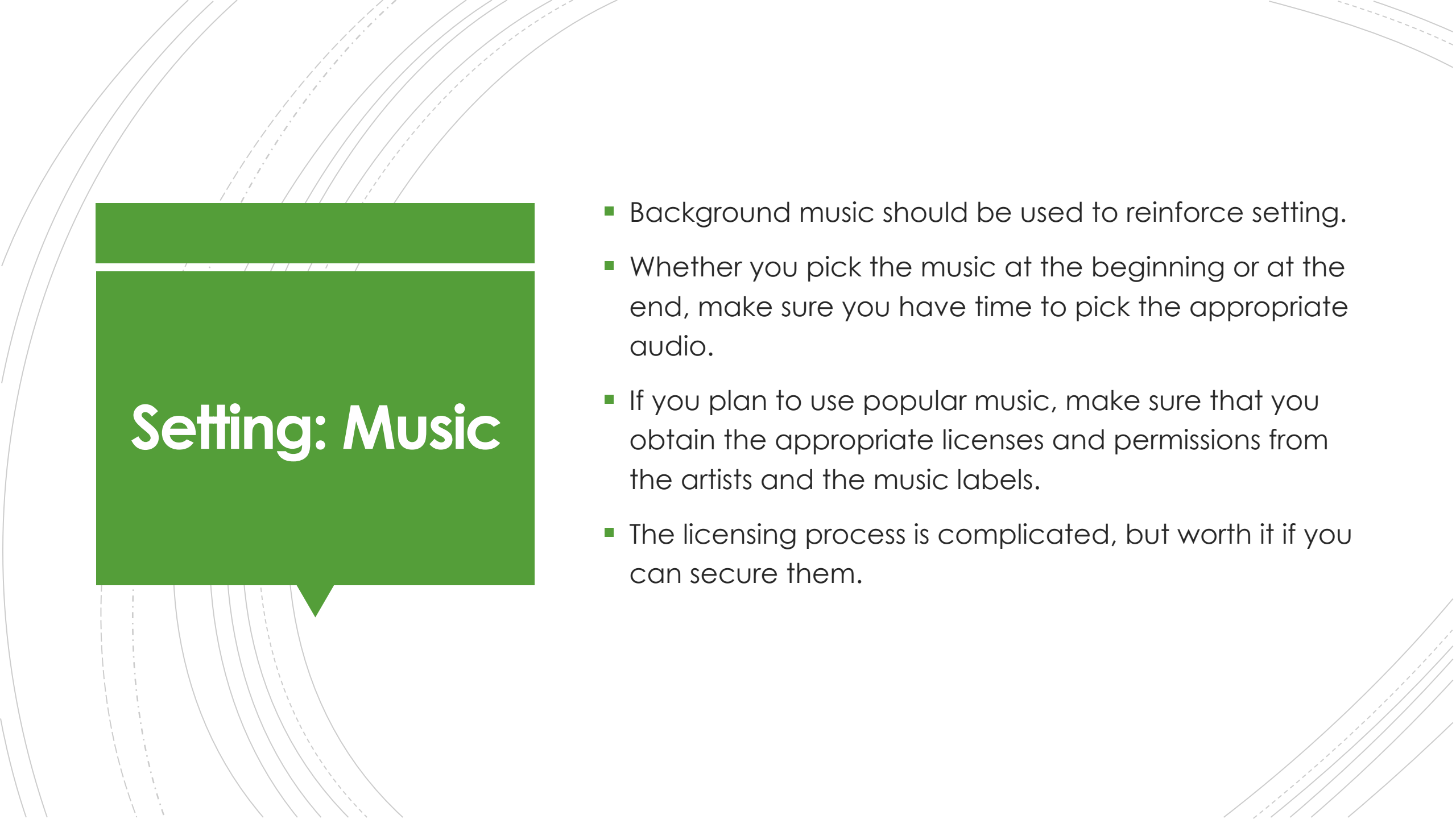
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Setting: Audio & Voices

- Don't be afraid to tell people what you're looking for. A good multimedia producer is like a good director, they know what they want and communicate that effectively to the talent.
- When recording audio, take the time to record the environment.
- Sometimes recording audio inside the studio may be clearer, but you may miss an opportunity to increase the audience's involvement.

Setting: Music

- Background music should be used to reinforce setting.
- Whether you pick the music at the beginning or at the end, make sure you have time to pick the appropriate audio.
- If you plan to use popular music, make sure that you obtain the appropriate licenses and permissions from the artists and the music labels.
- The licensing process is complicated, but worth it if you can secure them.

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Theme

- The theme is the point you're trying to get across by presenting the story. It's the reason for the project. Theme may involve a moral imperative you're trying to teach the viewer. It may simply be the subject of your project.
- It's important to consider your theme when developing your presentation.
- Following your theme keeps your project focused.
- Theme is one of the first questions that should come up in team discussions.

Theme

Ask yourself:

- Why are we doing this project?
- What is the single conclusion the viewers should reach after experiencing the presentation?
- How should viewers act after experiencing this presentation?

These types of questions will help you decide on a theme. Write a sentence that defines your theme; it should contain a single idea that defines the theme clearly.

THREE ACT Structure

- Whether you're watching a show on television, reading a good novel, or checking out the latest motion picture, chances are the medium is set in the **traditional three-act structure**.
- Aristotle explained the three-act structure as the ideal way to organize a story. Although all multimedia projects will not be set up in this fashion, you should study this structure because it demonstrates how to organize your projects so that your audience remains interested.
- A well-executed, three-act structure is flawless for building interest.

Three act structure

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Three act Structure: Act 1

- In a typical motion picture, ACT I lasts about 20 minutes. In a book, it typically includes an event called the hook that grabs the viewer's attention.
- A major plot point is introduced in ACT I. On television, you'll know when ACT I ends, because it places the main characters in danger and is quickly followed by commercials.
- ACT I introduces the main characters, establishes the situation, and begins to establish the setting. Most of the time, ACT I introduces the conflict the characters are experiencing. It's the most important part of a television show.

Three act Structure: Act 1

- If it's bad, people stop watching. If it's good, people won't want it to end. ACT I sets up the conflict the hero or main character has to overcome.
- Whatever you work on, make sure you remember the way movies and television shows use ACT I.
- It's the shortest of the three acts and its purpose is to entice viewers to maintain their focus on your presentation.

Three act Structure: ACT II

- ACT II is usually longer than the other acts. It's where most of the action takes place and is the middle of the story. Near the end of ACT II, a second plot point is introduced. Through this second plot point, viewers can see the light at the end of the tunnel. ACT II sets up the events that bring about the resolution of the conflict.
- If ACT I introduces the conflict or the goal the hero must achieve, then ACT II presents a series of obstacles that must be overcome. This is what makes the story interesting.
- A good story builds up into a larger and larger crescendo of obstacles that culminate in the introduction of the final plot point that brings about the resolution.

Three act Structure: ACT III

- ACT III brings the story to an end. It also brings about the resolution to the conflict established earlier.
- In addition to bringing the physical events to a conclusion, a good act III also emphasizes the theme of the movie. Your viewers should leave with a sense that they have learned something from the experience—something about your characters and perhaps something about themselves.
- A good finish is at least as important as a good start; otherwise your viewers leave feeling dissatisfied.